CHAPTER 7

Playing Nice with JavaScript

We're living in a JavaScript renaissance—no longer is it the whipping boy of language purists. Rails has embraced modern JavaScript technologies like React through its inclusion of `Webpacker`: a gem that brings `webpack` support.

As Rails developers, it's important to be able to incorporate these technologies into our apps as needed, so our Docker environment needs to support us in that endeavor.

In this chapter, we'll explore the options for working with JavaScript as part of our Rails development. We'll also see how to include a React front end in our Rails app by installing and configuring `Webpacker`.

By the end of this chapter, our Docker-based development environment will play nice with all this modern JavaScript goodness.

The JavaScript Front-End Options

There are a number of different options when it comes to combining JavaScript into the front end for your Rails apps. Perhaps the biggest choice is whether your Rails app will serve up the front end or not. Both are equally valid options, and each way has some advantages and disadvantages and will lead to different setups.

If your Rails app is not serving up your front end, that means you're using your Rails app as an API layer. In this case, you'd have a separate front end, typically written purely in JavaScript, whether that's React, Ember, Vue.js, or something else. This scenario is outside the scope of the book, since it involves getting very JavaScript-specific with your setup. However, in general terms, it's quite straightforward, and you will largely be applying the skills you've already learned.